Week 11: The Book of Psalms

How to Read the Bible — 19-Week Study

The book of Psalms is more than a collection of individual prayers — tonight we'll spend time in a few of them and see how they fit together.

1. What's your go-to way of processing hard emotions — journaling, talking it out, going quiet, something else? Where does prayer typically fit into that for you, if at all?

2. **Read Psalm 1.** What does the psalm say the righteous person does and doesn't do (vv. 1-2), and what happens to each of the two ways of life by the end (vv. 4-6)? What would it practically look like for you to "delight in" Scripture, as this psalm puts it, rather than treat it as an obligation to check off?

3. **Read Psalm 2.** What are the nations doing at the start of this psalm, and how does God respond (vv. 1-6)? Where do you see this same kind of defiance — human power resisting God's rule — playing out in the world today?

4. Psalms 1 and 2 were placed together on purpose to introduce the entire book — one centered on God's instruction, the other on God's coming king. Why might it matter that every reader encounters both of these themes before anything else in the book?

5. **Read Psalm 13.** What are the four "how long" questions David asks at the start, and what shift happens by the end of the psalm (vv. 1-2, 5-6)? This short lament opens with these questions before David ever asks God for anything specific. Why do you think it matters that raw complaint gets this much room in Scripture, instead of being rushed past for something more "positive"?

6. **Read Psalm 23.** What images does David use for God in this psalm, and what does he say God does for him along the way (vv. 1-3, 5)? Set its calm, settled confidence against Psalm 13's desperation from a moment ago. What does it tell you that both an anguished psalm and a peaceful one sit in the same book as equally valid ways of talking to God?

7. In Psalm 23, David pictures God as a shepherd who leads him *through* "the valley of the shadow of death" rather than around it. Has there been a season where you felt God leading you through hardship rather than sparing you from it? What was that like?

8. **Read Psalm 150.** What reasons and what instruments does this psalm list for praising God (vv. 1-5)? Why do you think the book ends on pure praise rather than resolving every lament that came before it?

9. The Psalms range from desperate complaint to quiet confidence to unrestrained joy, sometimes within just a few pages of each other. What does it tell you about God that Scripture makes room for such a wide range of honest prayer?

10. If you had to write your own psalm this week — either a Psalm 13 or a Psalm 150 — which one would honestly reflect where you are with God right now? What's one line you'd want to say to him?